

Panels that don't legislate are back

Despite no hearings, chairs get stipends

By Emma Platoff and Laura Crimaldi
GLOBE STAFF

Leaders of the Massachusetts House and Senate have brought back 12 legislative committees that in the previous session did not hold a single hearing or consider a single bill, and in many cases kept the same chairs for positions that earn tens of thousands of dollars in additional pay.

In just a few cases, the leaders of the two chambers shuffled the past heads of those committees to other panels that traditionally consider legislation.

The Globe reported in May that more than one in five committees did little or no legislating, yet their leaders received substantial additional pay. One senator who

►House leaders adopt new rules package. B1.

chaired two committees that did not hold a single public hearing or consider a single bill during the session received \$61,000 in leadership stipends.

Senate President Karen Spilka declined to directly answer why those committees were reconvened, while a spokesperson for House Speaker Ronald Mariano argued that some of them perform advisory or management functions rather than consider legislation.

A spokesperson for Spilka instead reissued a statement on her latest leadership picks, which declared that she has “great faith that our chamber will continue to be proactive and responsive” in its work.

Traditionally, committees

COMMITTEES, Page A4

European leaders gathered in Brussels to discuss how to bolster both Europe's own defenses and its support for Ukraine. A3.

A thumb-size \$100 robot from MIT has arrived on the moon and will try to determine if robots could someday repair spaceships. B5.

A shift in vaccine planning could make the next flu season worse, doctors said. B1.

Henry David Thoreau visited Providence to deliver a lecture in 1854 and took a long walk. It's possible to retrace it today. B1.

‘It is either clean and safe or it’s not. And if it’s not, then it shouldn’t be that way in this state or in this country.’

STEPHEN BANNON, chair of the Great Barrington Select Board



BRETT PHELPS FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Kate Van Olst said that her son, Orion, wonders about the safety of bathing in brown water, and that she isn't sure what to tell him. Van Olst said the water has gotten worse over the past five years.

Not loving that dirty water

Long-suffering Housatonic residents want action now

By Erin Douglas
GLOBE STAFF

GREAT BARRINGTON — After the water began to turn brown, Kate Van Olst took her baby daughter to the pediatrician for a blood test and paid \$400 for a filter to treat their drinking and cooking water.

Bath time, though, with unfiltered water, still provokes questions.

“It’s not pleasant to put a child in a brown bathtub,” Van Olst said. “Every summer, my [9-year-old] son says, ‘Are you sure this is safe?’ and I don’t have the answer.”

For at least eight years, residents of this small town in Western Massachusetts have dealt with bouts of brown water flowing from their taps. From approximately Memorial Day to Labor Day, hundreds of residents in Housatonic, a village in Great Barrington with a population of just over 1,000, aren’t sure what color their water will be. Sometimes it’s like tea, other days, coffee. Clothes come out of the wash with stains.

WATER, Page A5



KATE VAN OLST

High levels of manganese turn tap water brown in the warmer months. It seems to be safe to use, but many residents make other arrangements.

Trump backs off again on tariffs

With markets tumbling, he drops many levies on Canada and Mexico

By Ana Swanson and Alan Rappeport
NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — Two days after imposing tariffs on Canada and Mexico, President Trump on Thursday abruptly suspended many of those levies, sowing confusion with investors and businesses that depend on trade with the countries.

The president said he would allow products that are traded under the rules of the US-Mexico-Canada Agreement, the trade pact he signed in his first term, to avoid the stiff 25 percent tariffs he imposed just days ago on two of America’s largest trading partners.

The suspension effectively abandons many of the tariffs that Trump had placed on Canadian and Mexican products — levies he said were necessary to stem the flow of drugs and migrants into the United States.

His decision came a day after he said he would grant a 30-day reprieve to automakers, which had complained to the president that the levies would cause severe damage to US carmakers. Trump implied that any relief would be short-lived, saying that other tariffs on Canadian and Mexican products are coming in April.

TARIFFS, Page A7

NIH abruptly terminates millions in research grants

By Kay Lazar and Liz Kowalczyk
GLOBE STAFF

In an unprecedented move, the National Institutes of Health is abruptly terminating millions of dollars in research awards to scientists in Massachusetts and around the country, citing the Trump administration’s new restrictions on funding anything related to diversity, equity, and inclusion, transgender issues, or research that could potentially benefit universities in China.

The sweeping actions would appear to violate court rulings from federal judges in Rhode Island and Washington, D.C., that block the Trump administration from freezing or ending billions of dollars in government spending, said David Super, a constitutional law expert at Georgetown Law, who reviewed some of the termination letters at the Globe’s request.

In a related case brought by an association of higher education officials that specifically challenged Trump’s various DEI executive orders, a federal judge in Maryland twice over

NIH, Page A7

►Judge extends order preventing administration from freezing billions of funds approved for states. A2.

In Somerville, fear of losing the soul of Davis Square

A proposed tower would bring much-needed housing but close the Burren, at least for a while

By Spencer Buell
GLOBE STAFF

SOMERVILLE — To the musicians squeezed in tight around it on Sunday, the scuffed, scraped, dented tabletop in a corner of the Burren is more than a piece of furniture.

“This is a corner that was built by musicians, for musicians,” said Shannon Heaton, who plays the Irish flute and regularly performs with local artists who with their guitars, banjos, mandolins, and fiddles fill the pub with traditional Celtic music. “It takes a lot of effort to build community, to maintain it and sustain it,” she said.

That community fears it may lose the Burren, and more broadly, the authenticity of an eclectic and vibrant neighborhood, if a proposed 25-story residential tower is built here, shutting the bar along with a meat market, a pizza shop, and a restaurant.

The project has put the Burren and Davis

Square itself at the center of a push-and-pull playing out in hip corners of US cities as they try to solve an acute housing shortage without snuffing out their spark. The way musicians around the table saw it — some of whom, like Heaton, moved across the country just to play here — the choice between preserving the Davis Square people love or replacing it with a shiny, sanitized version with yet another shopping center under luxury units, is hardly a choice at all.

Somerville officials disagree that culture and lots more housing are at odds. Opportunities to add places to live here can’t just be waved off, said Tom Galligani, the city’s chief of planning, who believes it is possible to build upward without wiping out what was there before. Cities such as Somerville, Cambridge, and Boston just need to be creative, he said.

“It really comes down to a question of, ‘How

BURREN, Page A5



MATTHEW J. LEE/GLOBE STAFF

The music has been playing for decades at the Irish pub. “You take the Burren out of the equation and it’s the death blow to the music community,” Tom Bianchi said.



A fair shake

Friday: Sunny but windy. High 43-48. Low 30-35.

Saturday: Cool, breezy. High 39-44. Low 24-29.

Sunrise: 6:09 Sunset: 5:41

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